

State Response During Times of Emergency

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Introduction

In this paper, I would like to explore the issue of state response during times of emergency. I would like to understand contemporary research with relation to prominent ethical theories and form my opinion on the appropriateness of such responses. I would explore the issue through the lens of historical state responses and the use of technology during times of epidemics such as The Plague, or The Spanish Flu that required extreme measures to supposedly safeguard the lives of its citizens and the world at large. By the end of this paper, my goal is to have a concrete opinion about the technocultural measures being undertaken by the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) during the ongoing COVID-19 outbreak (Wu, Leung, & Leung).

I am interested in this issue because the COVID-19 outbreak is an ongoing development with immediate widespread implications across all spectrums of life: from the economy (Dongxiao, 2020) to the status quo of state power in the People's Republic of China (PRC) and potentially beyond (Yuan, 2020), from the rapid deployment of radically new technology (Srinivasan, 2020a) to the changes in cultural behavior (Srinivasan, 2020b) that would influence decades to come. As the World Health Organization (WHO) has declared COVID-19 to be a public health emergency of international concern (World Health Organization, 2020a) with over 73,000 confirmed cases and more than 1,800 deaths reported as of February 18, 2020 (World Health Organization, 2020b), it has become clear that COVID-19 is most likely to become a pandemic in coming days (Jung et al., 2020) which would mean increased state intervention closer home in the United States. Besides, we are already experiencing consequences of the outbreak in terms of supply chain disruptions (TrendForce, 2020) which has led to the cancellation of Mobile World Congress, the world's largest smartphone conference (Ha, 2020). All companies based in or with branches in mainland China have suspended all business travel

and shut down offices and factories resulting in massive impact on the world economy (McDonald, 2020) with various conferences worldwide cancelled (Ghaffary, 2020), (Ha, 2020), (CBS, 2020), (Geddie, 2020), (Knight, 2020). Perhaps this is the event that brings the world economy into a depression given the global economic slowdown. Finally, I am also interested in this issue because of the rapid deployment of experimental and non-mainstream technologies as UAVs to remotely surveil citizens, record their vitals, disinfect, and police streets to enforce the quarantine (Novak, 2020); the close-contact detector app that traces an individual's steps to supposedly help identify those who've come in contact with the infected people (Chen, 2020); and so much more.

As apparent, these wide ranging implications are directly influenced by actions of the state. I am not sure what the right state response is supposed to be. On the one hand, the WHO, rightly so, praises CCP efforts of containing the virus through widespread quarantine and mobilization of state efforts (Joseph & Thielking, 2020) but on the other hand, over 700M people today are under forced quarantine (Zhong & Mozur, 2020) alongside various alleged human rights violations (Amnesty International, 2020). On the one hand, CCP is accused of “downplaying” the COVID-19 outbreak (Cadell, 2020) whereby it punished those who voiced their concerns about the novel coronavirus (Kavanagh, 2020) but on the other hand, it is obliged to do so in order to maintain peace and calm and avoid a state of panic. On the one hand, WHO claims that the travel restrictions employed by a majority of states worldwide are unnecessary and have the effect of increasing fear and stigma (Nebehay, 2020) but on the other hand, we know that the virus has spread outside mainland china through international travellers (Corman et al., 2020) and so states have a responsibility of protecting their citizens who could be infected as asymptomatic transmissions make it impossible to check every traveller at the point

of entry (Rothe et al., 2020). I am also concerned about the larger public propaganda machine initiated by the CCP whereby it's spreading an "all is well" narrative through all forms of media. There are mass dis-information bots on Twitter allegedly employed by CCP (Sinclair, 2020). Just today (February 18, 2020), the United States has recognized all CCP state media as foreign missions, stating that "China has been tightening state control over its media and President Xi Jinping has made more aggressive use of them to spread pro-Beijing propaganda" (Landay, 2020). Whilst these powers of state controlled media have existed in PRC for a long while (Chan, 2002), CCP has especially extended its power in recent times to control the public narrative of the outbreak. There are also concerns about the validity of reported outbreak data coming from PRC (Cadell, 2020). I am not sure whether it is justified to take such measures as they potentially bring order in society but at what cost?

To form my opinion on this issue, I would begin by researching a historical overview of state responses during wide scale pandemics such as The Plague (Green & Symes, 2015) and the Spanish Flu (Morens, Taubenberger, Harvey, & Memoli, 2010) alongside more recent widespread outbreaks like the SARS (Smith, 2006), Ebola (Moon et al., 2015) and H1N1 (Fineberg, 2014). Specifically, I would note what technocultural means were used by the states and how the society changed after each of these events. Next, I would analyze the literature on ethics of emergency / disaster management and summarize or categorize what the different perspectives are. The WHO has a training manual designed specifically for ethics in epidemics, emergencies and disasters (World Health Organization, 2015). Karadag et al (2012) elaborate the various ethical dilemmas faced during disasters and how various international organizations have laid down various ethical and legal guidelines to deal with such situations. (Harris, 1995), (Upshur et al., 2005), (Halpern, 2002), (Mercan-Irgil, 2000) discuss various ethical

considerations and responsibilities applicable during times of disaster preparedness and response.

The Ethics Subcommittee of the Advisory Committee of the Director, Centers for Disease Control and Prevention also published a recommendation outlining Ethical Guidelines in Pandemic Influenza (Kinlaw, Barrett, & Levine, 2009). Finally, I would recognize these with respect to the ongoing COVID-19 outbreak (Habibi et al., 2020), further analyzing the technocultural changes that have since come in existence. I hope that this would help shed light on what's happening in the world around us today and further deepen our understanding about viewing such developments.

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